

Now that I have talked a lot of trash about expensive dream schools, I will say that there are a few exceptions. If your dream school is an “elite” institution like Harvard or Stanford, people may place more value on those degrees. Also, those schools often have tremendous networking opportunities that can hook you up with jobs in the future. Another reason to choose your dream school is if they have a specialized program that is known to be one of the best. For example, if you want to be a nurse and the school you love is the top nursing school in the country, you may be justified in spending more money on that opportunity. Even then, you need to weigh your future salary against the cost of the school.

I am also not saying to choose the cheapest school possible. Like any financial choice, you need to examine the value of each school. If your dream school is only going to cost \$10,000 more total, it may be worth it. If, however, your dream school is going to bury you in debt and seriously cut into your future financial freedom, it is not worth it.

The FAFSA

Paying for college is going to begin with the **Free Application for Federal Student Aid**, or **FAFSA**. The FAFSA is an application that will determine whether or not you are going to receive aid to pay for college and how much you will receive. You complete the FAFSA using your personal financial information and/or the financial information of your family. Before you begin the FAFSA, you need to determine whether you are considered a dependent or independent student. In short, a dependent student is assumed to have the financial support of parents, so their parents’ financial